



RESCUED CHILDREN  
BACK IN THEIR  
VILLAGE PARARIA,  
MADHEPURA DIS-  
TRICT, AFTER THEY  
WERE FREED FROM  
TRAFFICKERS TAKING  
THEM TO PUNJAB

Mahto says there are over 12,000 children who have been trafficked to metropolitan cities from areas hit by the Kosi floods between October and December 2008. The BBA's data is based on a survey of not just the flood-affected areas but also train ticket details from six railway stations in the Kosi zone. And ever since the floods struck, volunteers of NGOs have been looking for victims, rescuing them from the clutches of their tormentors. Bihar State Child Labour Commission Chairman Ramdev Prasad confirms that 2,000 children from the state have been rescued so far.

Even as recently as a fortnight ago, a dozen children were freed at the Supaul railway station. Rajesh Kumar

Singh of Abhilasha Pariwar, an NGO in Katihar district, claims, "Almost everyone in the six districts of Saharsa, Madhepura, Supaul, Purnea, Araria and Katihar has had to suffer after the Kosi floods. The traffickers have exploited these poor people to let go their children for a pittance."

Many a time, the children are simply picked up without the knowledge of their family members. A case in point is 11-year-old Chhotu, an orphan from Pararia in Madhepura, who was rescued on January 8 by the Saharsa police while traffickers were taking him and 11 other children to Punjab. The traffickers had lured Chhotu with fancy food and candies to get him to go with them to a "big city".

## What happens to trafficked children?

Nearly 12,000 children are believed to have been trafficked, sometimes for as little as Rs 500. Rescued children say they have been made to work for more than 14 hours a day, just for two square meals. They are made to take care of cattle, do domestic work and water fields. Are beaten if they dare ask for money.